treating his elder brother as a father; Khanzada had negotiated between Humayun, Askari and Kamran. So, now, Hamida pleaded for peace between Akbar and Salim.

'She was devoted to the young Prince,' say the Jesuits, 'and fearing that he would be vanquished in an encounter with a veteran warrior like the King, she tried her utmost to turn the latter from his purpose.'[8]

Her arguments must have been persuasive. Akbar agreed to a truce. It was another of the women who went to bring Salim home: his aunt Salima, Akbar's cousin and wife, once married to Bairam Khan and a woman of renowned intelligence. 'She possessed all good qualities,' Salim would write of her years later, with gratitude.[9]

Salim and Salima returned to Agra in April 1603. Hamida came out to meet him, 'soothed the prince's terrified soul' and took him to Akbar.[10] To all appearances, father and son were reconciled. Akbar even put his own turban on Salim's head. But such goodwill between the men, if it existed at all, did not last long. Akbar had not forgotten Abul Fazl. It was soon after Salim's arrival that Abul Fazl's son came to court; Akbar condoled with him and gave him a special shawl – a pashmina, which Akbar called '*parm-narm*', so-so-soft.

As for Salim, the prince may have grown accustomed to his own rule over the past two years. To be back in court, subordinate to the emperor, does not seem to have suited him. Six months later, Akbar gave Salim a mission against Mewar but the prince went back to Allahabad instead – to the satisfaction, it seems, of both parties.

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There are so few moments of rest in the *Akbarnama*, so much conquest and debate, so much travel and diplomacy, that it is easy to forget that Akbar was a bookworm. It had long been Akbar's custom, and his great pleasure, '[a]fter the lights had been lit . . . to sit in a great hall', as the Jesuits describe it, 'surrounded by numerous people whose duty it was to read books to him, or narrate stories'.[11] After these daily readings, Akbar would make a mark on the page where the reader had stopped and reward him with gold or silver coins.[12]

Akbar was famously illiterate – or, more likely, dyslexic, as modern